

AM Compass — Design System Brief

AM Compass

June 14, 2026

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AM Compass — Design System Brief

A complete, self-contained brief for designing the AM Compass design system. The reader is assumed to know **nothing** about this product or the asset-management industry — domain terms are explained inline. The goal of this document is to give a design partner everything needed to produce a proper, scalable design system (tokens, components, data-viz language, patterns, templates, states) that serves the product today and through its full roadmap.

1. What AM Compass is — in one paragraph

AM Compass (“Asset Management Compass”) is a **competitive-intelligence and strategy cockpit for asset managers** — the firms that build and sell investment funds (e.g. BlackRock/iShares, Vanguard, State Street/SPDR, Amundi). It lets a fund issuer **monitor competitors’ products, fees, holdings, documents and launches**, and — its signature capability — **reverse-engineer competitors’ company and product strategy** from observable evidence. Think “Bloomberg-grade depth, but focused on competitive product/market strategy, and far more modern and self-serve.” Every strategic conclusion the product draws is **traceable to a source signal** (no black box) — that auditability is a core product value and must be expressed in the design.

It is NOT a digital-marketing/SEO tool (not a Similarweb/Ahrefs clone). Web-traffic, search-ranking and ad-spend analytics are explicitly out of scope. The center of gravity is **products, portfolios, fees, performance, documents, flows, signals and strategy**.

2. The core idea behind the product (the mental model)

An asset manager is structurally a **catalogue retailer of financial products**. This analogy drives the whole product and should inform the design’s information architecture:

Retail concept	Asset-management equivalent	Plain meaning
Retailer / brand	Issuer / fund family	The company (BlackRock → iShares)
Product	Fund / ETF	The thing you buy
SKU / variant	Share class	A version of a fund (currency, fee, income style)
Barcode (GTIN)	ISIN	Unique 12-char product ID
Price tag	TER / fee	Annual % cost of owning the fund
Product page	Factsheet / KIID	The disclosure documents
Sales channel	Platform / broker / exchange	Where you buy it
Revenue / GMV	Net flows / AUM	Money gathered; total assets held
Customer	Investor	Retail person, advisor, or institution

So the product is, in spirit, “competitive product intelligence for a catalogue retailer” — but the catalogue is funds, the specs are financial (returns, risk, fees, holdings), and the strategy questions are about where a competitor is expanding, retreating, cutting prices, or launching.

3. Domain vocabulary the design must speak correctly

The UI must use precise industry language. Key terms (the design system’s labels, tooltips, and example content should use these correctly):

- **Issuer / fund family** — the company that runs the funds (BlackRock/iShares).
- **Product / fund / ETF** — an investable strategy. **ETF** = exchange-traded fund (trades like a stock). **Mutual fund / index fund** = bought/sold once a day. **SMA** (separately managed account), **model portfolio**, **CIT**, **direct indexing** = other “wrappers” — collectively the **vehicle spectrum**.
- **Share class** — a variant of one fund (e.g. USD vs EUR, accumulating vs distributing income, retail vs institutional fee tier).
- **ISIN / ticker** — product identifiers. ISIN is the global ID; ticker is the short exchange symbol.
- **TER / OCF** — Total Expense Ratio / Ongoing Charges — the annual fee, the headline “price.” Quoted in % (e.g. 0.20%).

- **AUM** — Assets Under Management — total money in a fund (its “size”/popularity).
 - **NAV** — Net Asset Value — the per-unit price, struck daily.
 - **Flows / net new assets** — money coming in (or leaving, “redemptions/outflows”) over a period. The “revenue” signal.
 - **Benchmark / index** — the reference a fund tracks or is measured against (e.g. MSCI World, S&P 500).
 - **Holdings** — the underlying securities a fund owns (its “bill of materials”).
 - **Return (1y/3y/5y)** — historical performance. **TWR** = time-weighted return, the standard method.
 - **Risk metrics** — **volatility** (how bumpy), **Sharpe ratio** (return per unit of risk), **max draw-down** (worst peak-to-trough loss), **tracking difference/error** (how closely an index fund follows its benchmark).
 - **Fixed income** = bonds. **Equity** = stocks. **Asset class** = the broad type (equity, fixed income, commodities, multi-asset).
 - **Active vs passive** — manager-picked vs index-tracking. A major strategic axis.
 - **ESG / SFDR** — sustainability classification (SFDR Articles 6/8/9 = rising sustainability tiers).
 - **Domicile** — where a fund is legally registered (Ireland, Luxembourg). **UCITS** = the EU regulatory regime for retail funds.
 - **NFO / launch · closure / liquidation · merger** — product lifecycle events.
 - **Signal** — in AM Compass: a detected competitor event/change (a fee change, a launch, a holdings shift, an AUM trend).
 - **Brief / dossier** — an AM Compass output: a synthesized strategy read about a competitor, with every claim cited to signals.
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4. Who it’s for (personas)

The product is a **professional B2B tool** used by sophisticated finance professionals at fund-issuing firms. They are analytical, data-fluent, time-pressed, and skeptical (they will not trust conclusions they can’t verify). Desktop-first; often dual-monitor; comfortable with dense data (many already live in Bloomberg/Morningstar/Excel).

Primary (v1):

- **Product Strategy** — decides what funds to launch, in which exposure, at what fee. Wants: white-space/gaps, fee benchmarking, competitor positioning, launch/closure tracking, “where is the market moving.”

- **ETF Capital Markets** — wants competitor launches, benchmark/index choice, flows by exposure, liquidity & listings. (Some capabilities here are later-phase.)

Secondary / future:

- **Competitive Intelligence / Strategy** teams — peer monitoring, league tables, “what is BlackRock doing right now.”
- **Distribution / Sales** — channel & platform penetration, where flows are going.
- **Marketing** — brand & positioning (narrower role here than in a digital tool).
- **Executives** — high-level scorecards and briefings.

Design implication: the product must serve **both** the deep analyst (dense tables, drill-down, exports) **and** the executive skimmer (scorecards, one-line takeaways, briefings). Two reading altitudes in one system.

5. The two altitudes (a structural design requirement)

The product operates at two zoom levels; the IA and navigation must make both first-class and let users move between them:

1. **Market altitude (top-down):** “I’m considering entering **fixed income** — what’s offered, who does what, where would my product sit, and **where is the market structurally moving** (e.g. money migrating from old-style mutual funds into ETFs and SMAs)?” → segment landscapes, who-does-what maps, offering inventories, white-space, positioning, migration/flow-direction.
 2. **Competitor altitude (bottom-up):** “What is **BlackRock** doing — where are they expanding, cutting fees, launching, retreating?” → per-issuer dossiers, move timelines, inferred strategy with cited evidence.
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6. Information architecture — current and full future

This is the full surface inventory the design system must eventually support. **v1 (built)** is marked; the rest is roadmap the system should scale to gracefully.

LAYER 0 — DATA FOUNDATION (MOSTLY BEHIND THE SCENES, BUT NEEDS ADMIN/COVERAGE UI)

- Issuer registry, product catalog (full vehicle spectrum), share-class explorer

- Identity/coverage management; **data-coverage map** (which issuers/segments have which data depth) — *v1 has a simple version*
- Document corpus browser (factsheets, KIIDs, prospectuses, holdings, annual reports)

LAYER 1 — UNIVERSE / LENS BUILDER

- **Lens selector**: choose what to compare by — Issuer · Index/benchmark · Category (asset class → region) · Market segment (style/factor/theme/risk/cost) · Exposure · Geography · Client segment
- **Peer-set builder** (define & save a competitive set); **watchlists**; saved views/projects

LAYER 2 — MONITORING & DOCUMENT INTELLIGENCE

- Continuous competitor product monitoring
- **Document version-diff viewer** (show what changed between two versions of a factsheet/KIID/holdings file — the “before → after”)
- Holdings-change tracker; news/regulatory feed; manager-commentary analysis

LAYER 3 — COMPARISON & ANALYTICS MODULES

- **Market Structure & Opportunity** — segment landscape, who-does-what, offering inventory, **entry white-space + positioning simulator** (“if I launch here, where do I sit?”) (*v1 has a basic version*)
- **Product & Catalog** — side-by-side product compare; catalog gap; launch/closure/merger lifecycle
- **Pricing & Fee** — fee benchmarking; price positioning; fee-war tracking (*v1*)
- **Performance & Risk** — returns, Sharpe, drawdown, tracking difference, fixed-income & ESG views (*v1*)
- **Flows & Market-Share** — net flows, AUM league tables, share-of-flows (*future; needs licensed data*)
- **Holdings & Portfolio** — overlap, concentration, factor/sector exposure (*v1 has concentration*)
- **ETF Capital Markets** — listings/cross-listings, liquidity, spreads (*future*)
- **Distribution & Availability** — platform penetration, registrations (*future*)

LAYER 4 — STRATEGY REVERSE-ENGINEERING (THE FLAGSHIP)

- **Competitor strategy dossier** — inferred strategy (expanding/retreating/fee-strategy/distribution-push) with **evidence-cited claims** (*v1 built*)
- **Move timeline / playbook detection** — sequence of competitor actions over time

- **Structural-shift / migration view** — “where the market is moving” (vehicle migration, active→passive, etc.) (*future*)
- **Predictive / what-next** (*far future*)

LAYER 5 — SIGNALS & ALERTS

- **Signal feed** (filterable list of detected events) (*v1 built*)
- Alerting/notifications on watchlists; anomaly detection

LAYER 6 — COCKPIT, OUTPUT & WORKSPACE

- **Issuer scorecards / dossiers** (*v1*); **side-by-side compare** views
 - **Dashboards** (composable), **scheduled briefings/reports, exports**
 - Workspace: teams/roles, saved views, search/command palette, settings, API
 - Auth, onboarding, account, billing (*future*)
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7. Key user journeys (design for these end-to-end)

1. **“Scan a segment I might enter.”** Pick lens → see segment landscape (size, players, offerings, fees, where money’s moving) → spot white-space → simulate my product’s positioning.
 2. **“Reverse-engineer a competitor.”** Open issuer dossier → read inferred strategy → drill each claim to its evidence signals → see the move timeline → export a briefing.
 3. **“Monitor and get alerted.”** Build a watchlist → receive signals (fee cut, launch, holdings drift) → triage the feed → open the detail/diff.
 4. **“Compare head-to-head.”** Select N products or issuers → side-by-side on fees/performance/risk/holdings.
 5. **“Investigate a change.”** A signal fires → open the document version-diff → see exactly what changed and the inferred meaning.
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8. Content & data characteristics (drives the visual system)

The design system must excel at **dense, precise, trustworthy financial data**:

- **Tabular, numeric, comparative.** Many tables with tabular-figure numbers, %, currency (multi-currency), large counts. Needs first-class **data-table patterns**: sortable, sticky headers/columns, alignment, conditional coloring (above/below peer, gains/losses), compact and comfortable densities, row drill-down, column pinning, horizontal scroll for many peers.

- **Time series.** NAV/return/AUM histories → **line/area charts**; returns/flows by period → **bar charts**; “where money is moving” → **diverging bar / flow** visuals. Charts must read in both light and dark, be color-blind safe, and never rely on color alone.
 - **Comparison.** Side-by-side of 2–N entities; “vs peer median” framing; rank/percentile.
 - **Events & timelines.** Signals are dated events with types → **feed** and **timeline** patterns; type badges; confidence and detection-method tags.
 - **Evidence-cited narrative.** Strategy briefs are prose where **every claim links to source signals** → an elegant **citation/evidence pattern** (inline chips that reveal/scroll-to the underlying signal; an “evidence index”). This is a signature interaction — make it beautiful and trustworthy.
 - **Document diffs.** Before→after views of fee/holdings/text changes → a clean **diff pattern** (additions/removals, old→new).
 - **Uncertainty & provenance.** Data confidence varies. The system must visually distinguish: **measured fact vs inferred conclusion** (“inferred, not stated”), **confidence levels** (high/medium/low), **estimated/directional vs precise**, and **data freshness/as-of dates**. This is critical for trust in a finance tool.
 - **Coverage gaps.** Some competitors have rich data, many have only documents. The UI must gracefully show **partial coverage** (“structured data not available for this issuer yet”) without feeling broken.
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9. Component inventory the design system should deliver

Foundational + domain-specific components (with all states):

Foundations: color tokens (incl. semantic + data-viz ramps), typography scale (incl. tabular numerics + mono for IDs), spacing, radius, elevation, grid/layout, iconography, motion.

Core UI: app shell (top bar, primary nav, lens/context selector), tabs, buttons, inputs, selects, multi-select, search, **command palette**, chips/filters, badges/tags, tooltips, popovers, modals/drawers, toasts, pagination, breadcrumbs, segmented controls, skeleton loaders, empty/error states.

Data & domain:

- **Metric/stat cards** (label + big number + delta/trend)
- **Data tables** (the workhorse — many variants: peer comparison, holdings, league table; sticky/pinned, sortable, conditional formatting, density toggle, expandable rows, exportable)
- **Comparison view** (2–N entities side-by-side)

- **Charts:** line/area (time series), bar (periodic returns/flows), diverging bar (net flows by vehicle), small sparklines (in-table), donut (allocation), scatter (risk/return). A coherent **data-viz sub-system** with shared palette, axes, legends, tooltips, empty/loading states.
 - **Signal feed item + timeline** (dated events, type badges, method/confidence tags, filterable)
 - **Evidence/citation chip + evidence index** + claim-with-citations block
 - **Document diff viewer** (before→after, add/remove)
 - **Issuer/product scorecard / dossier** template
 - **Lens / universe builder** (faceted selection, saved sets, watchlists)
 - **Positioning/white-space visual** (where a product would sit vs the field)
 - **Coverage/availability indicator** (data depth per issuer/segment)
 - **Confidence / “inferred” markers, as-of/freshness badges, provenance/source link**
 - **Alert/notification** components; **dashboard tile/grid**; **briefing/report** layout (print/export-friendly)
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10. States, edge cases & labels to design

Every data surface needs: **loading** (skeletons), **empty** (no results / not in scope), **error**, **partial/coverage-limited**, **stale/as-of**, **estimated/directional** (explicitly labelled, visually distinct from precise data), **inferred vs measured**, **confidence: high/medium/low**, and **constructed/demo** (for example data). Numbers must format correctly per locale (decimal/thousands separators differ in EU) and per currency. Negative values, percentages, and basis points need consistent treatment.

11. Design principles (the values the system should embody)

1. **Evidence over black box.** Auditability is a product value, not an afterthought. Conclusions visibly link to evidence; provenance and as-of dates are always reachable. The design should *feel* trustworthy and verifiable.
2. **Density without clutter.** Power users want a lot on screen; the system must make dense data scannable through hierarchy, alignment, restraint, and tabular numerics — not by hiding everything behind clicks.
3. **Two altitudes, one system.** Support both the skim (scorecards, one-line takeaways) and the deep dive (tables, drill-down, raw signals) without two disjoint design languages.

4. **Calm, professional, modern.** This is a serious financial tool (credibility matters) but should feel markedly more modern and approachable than legacy terminals (Bloomberg/Morningstar). Confident, quiet, precise — not flashy, not toy-like.
 5. **Speed & scannability.** Fast to parse; the most important number/takeaway is obvious; color and weight encode meaning consistently.
 6. **Comparison-native.** The product is fundamentally about comparison; “vs peer / vs benchmark / vs prior” framing should be a first-class, reusable pattern.
 7. **Honest about uncertainty.** Inferred $\neq$ measured; estimated $\neq$ precise; partial coverage is shown plainly. The design never overstates confidence.
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12. Brand, name & tone

- **Name:** AM Compass — *Asset Management Compass*. The “compass” idea = orientation, direction, navigating a competitive landscape, “where is the market heading.” A compass/navigation motif is a natural (but optional) brand anchor — use with restraint, avoid cliché.
 - **Voice:** precise, analytical, confident, plain-spoken. Explains finance without dumbing down. Never hypey. Labels are concise and correct.
 - **Tone in UI copy:** sentence case, no shouting, no exclamation. Numbers and evidence do the talking.
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13. Visual direction — current starting point (to formalize/improve, not blindly keep)

A working skeleton already exists with a **dark “cockpit” aesthetic**: near-black background, dark panels with subtle borders, blue accent, green/red for gains/losses, amber for watch/attention, gray for neutral, tabular numerics, compact tables, pill badges, monospace for IDs. It reads as a professional financial cockpit. **Treat this as a directional starting point, not a constraint** — the design partner should elevate it into a real system and is free to propose a stronger direction (including a refined light mode).

Hard requirements regardless of direction:

- **Both dark and light themes** (token-driven, switchable). Many finance users prefer dark; some institutions mandate light/print.
- **Color-blind-safe** data-viz; never encode meaning by color alone (pair with shape/label/pattern).

- **Tabular/lining numerals** everywhere numbers align; a **monospace** for IDs/codes.
 - **WCAG AA** contrast minimum.
 - A **semantic color system**: positive/negative (gains/losses, in/out flows), attention/warning, info/accent, neutral — plus a distinct **categorical palette** for chart series and signal types that works in both themes.
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14. Accessibility & internationalization

- WCAG 2.1 AA; full keyboard navigation (power users live on keyboard); visible focus; screen-reader-labelled tables/charts.
 - **Multi-language** content (English + German at least; the underlying data is multilingual — German factsheets etc.). Layouts must tolerate longer strings.
 - **Multi-currency & locale number/date formats** (EU decimal commas, \$/€/£, basis points, DD-MMM-YYYY).
 - Dense tables must remain accessible (proper semantics, not div soup).
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15. Platform, scale & technical context (for the design partner)

- **Web app, desktop-first** (primary use is at a desk, often wide/dual monitors); tablet a plus; phone is read-only/triage at most (briefings, alerts).
 - Current stack is **React + TypeScript** (Vite today; production stack still open). The design system should be delivered as **design tokens + component specs** that map cleanly to a React component library (and ideally a Figma library mirroring the components).
 - **Performance at scale**: tables of hundreds/thousands of rows (holdings), large peer sets, long time series. Components must be designed with virtualization/density in mind.
 - Theming via **tokens** (CSS variables) is required so dark/light and future white-label/theming are possible.
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16. Reference points (what to learn from / avoid)

- **Bloomberg Terminal / Eikon** — density and information richness to aspire to; but **avoid** their dated, cramped, intimidating feel. Be the modern answer.
- **Morningstar Direct, Nasdaq eVestment** — the incumbent fund-analytics tools; functional but heavy/clunky. We win on clarity and self-serve UX.

- **Koyfin, YCharts** — praised for clean, fast, modern financial UX for a similar audience; good interaction references.
 - **Linear, Vercel, Stripe dashboards** — for modern product polish, restraint, and dark-mode craft (general SaaS reference, not finance).
 - **Ahrefs / Similarweb dashboards** — competitive-intelligence interaction patterns (comparison, share-of, trend), even though our domain differs.
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17. The hard design challenges to solve (where the system earns its keep)

1. **Evidence/citation made elegant.** How a strategy claim shows its supporting signals — in-line, hover, drill — so it feels trustworthy and is pleasant, not noisy.
 2. **Inferred vs measured, and confidence.** A consistent visual language for “this is a conclusion, not a fact” and “high/medium/low confidence,” used across briefs, signals, and metrics.
 3. **Dense comparison that stays scannable.** N-way comparison tables/peer views that hold a lot yet remain instantly readable (vs-peer/vs-benchmark framing).
 4. **“Where the market is moving.”** Visualizing structural migration (money flowing between product types over time) intuitively.
 5. **Document diffs.** Showing what changed in a factsheet/holdings/fee between versions, cleanly.
 6. **Partial coverage without feeling broken.** Gracefully representing “rich data here, only documents there.”
 7. **Two altitudes in one nav.** Letting users move fluidly between market-level and competitor-level without a jarring context switch.
 8. **The lens/universe builder.** Making “choose what to compare, by which axis, and save it” powerful but not intimidating.
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18. What we’d like the design system to deliver

1. **Design tokens** — color (semantic + categorical + data-viz ramps, light & dark), typography (scale, tabular numerics, mono), spacing, radius, elevation, motion, breakpoints.
2. **Core component library** — every component in §9, with all states (§10), in light & dark, with accessibility specs.
3. **A data-visualization sub-system** — chart types, shared axes/legends/tooltips/empty states, palette, in-table sparklines, color-blind-safe rules.

4. **Signature patterns** — evidence/citation, signal-feed/timeline, comparison, document-diff, scorecard/dossier, confidence/uncertainty, coverage/provenance, lens/universe builder, positioning/white-space.
 5. **Page/template layouts** — for each major surface in §6 (dashboard, dossier, comparison, signal feed, segment landscape, document diff, briefing/report, settings, onboarding/empty).
 6. **Layout & grid system**, app-shell/navigation pattern (supporting the two altitudes), responsive behavior.
 7. **Iconography** and **brand expression** (logo/wordmark direction, the compass motif used tastefully).
 8. **Usage guidance** — density rules, number/locale formatting, do's/don'ts, voice & UI-copy guidelines.
 9. **A Figma library** mirroring the component library, token-linked, ready for engineering hand-off to React.
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19. Phasing (so the system scales, not over-builds)

- **Now (v1, built):** Market structure (peer table + coverage), Competitor dossier (cited claims + perf/risk), Signals feed — iShares/EU-UCITS, fixed income + equity. Prioritize nailing: data tables, metric cards, signal feed, evidence/citation, dossier, comparison, the dark theme.
- **Next:** more issuers/segments (multi-issuer market views), document-diff viewer, watchlists/alerts, dashboards & briefings, light theme, lens/universe builder.
- **Later:** flows/market-share (license-dependent), migration/structural-shift visuals, ETF capital-markets, distribution, predictive — plus account/auth/onboarding/billing and white-label theming.

Design the foundations and patterns now so the later surfaces slot into the same system without a redesign.

20. One-line summary for the design partner

Design a **trustworthy, dense-but-calm, dark-and-light, desktop-first** design system for a **competitive-intelligence cockpit for asset managers** — one that makes **comparison, evidence-cited strategy, and detected signals** feel precise and verifiable, scales from a 3-view skeleton to a full multi-module platform, and reads as the **modern successor to Bloomberg/Morningstar** for fund product & strategy teams.